

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

**MONUMENTAL MISPLANNING** The under-construction IPD tower at SMS Hospital near Albert Hall, Jaipur

**IPD TOWER, SMS HOSPITAL**
*Jaipur*
Ornamental 26-storey structure with twin helipads; cost escalated by Rs 200 crore; safety and design flaws flagged, ignored; operationally unsustainable
**Project cost:** ₹900 crore



**CHAMBAL RIVERFRONT,** *Kota*
Overbuilt concrete stretch with replicas of monuments; minimal visitors; running annual losses
**Project cost:** ₹1,500 crore

**EDUCATION HUB,** *Mansarovar, Jaipur*
Wrong projections, poor design; IIT Jodhpur refused to set up centre; complex largely unused
**Project cost:** ₹221 crore

**MLA AND OFFICER CLUBS**
*Jaipur*
Lavish recreational facilities built amid public infrastructure neglect
**Project cost:** ₹180 crore

**CARDIOLOGY CENTRE, SMS HOSPITAL,** *Jaipur*
Unsafe design; no access for fire engines, no basement parking; 20-month delay; unusable for intended purpose
**Project cost:** ₹93 crore

**MAHATMA GANDHI MUSEUM,** *Jaipur*
Heritage Laxmi Vilas Hotel razed to build the museum; it draws barely 140 visitors a month
**Project cost:** ₹80 crore

**FOUNTAIN SQUARE**
*Mansarovar, Jaipur*
Touted as tourist attraction; deserted
**Project cost:** ₹40 crore

**CHAUPATI FOOD COURTS,** *Jaipur and Kota*
Pitched as 'urban food destinations'; most stalls remain shut; poor footfall projections
**Project cost:** ₹32 crore (4 chaupatis)

*Project costs don't include land costs*

AC plant, making future expansion impossible. "Had they opted for a simpler, low-cost design, the work would have been done within the same budget," says an engineer involved in the project.

## BUILT TO FAIL?

Across the Trauma Centre road, another 'world-class' building is coming up—an incongruous 26-storey Indoor Patient Department (IPD) tower, which caught fire in January. The Rs 700 crore project, with twin helipads, ornamental columns, imported glass and marble interiors, was billed as SMS Hospital's modern face when launched in 2022. Its cost has since ballooned by Rs 200 crore and deadlines have slipped by over two years. "I wonder why the government has spent so heavily on the IPD tower," asks Vishwas Jain, managing director, Consulting Engineers Group, Jaipur. "Today, when supersonic jets can land on roads, couldn't a helicopter have landed on the basketball court across the road? Can a state that doesn't have its own helicopter afford to buy one for patients when only a few cases involve flying them to SMS?"

Even basic functionality has been sacrificed at the IPD tower. The proposed parking can accommodate barely half the vehicles expected daily. Authorities are scrambling to find space. The old mortuary beside the site is being shifted near the chief secretary's residence—drawing ridicule within the bureaucracy. "In SMS, we beg for wheelchairs and stretchers," says a senior doctor. "But crores are being poured into decorative pillars." He has a question: if the lift in the department for the physically challenged has been out of order for months, forcing them to climb the stairs, how will the many lifts in the IPD tower be maintained?

The first major alarm came in January 2024 when Dr B.P. Meena, deputy medical superintendent of SMS Medical College, flagged flaws in the IPD tower's design. There was no blueprint for patient movement, no departmental linkages and violation of hospital safety norms. His objections were ignored and he was transferred.

Successive governments have ignored Jaipur's heritage character by permitting highrises around protected zones. The IPD tower overshadows not only Albert Hall—a beautiful Indo-Saracenic structure built in 1887—but also the colonial-era colleges, buildings and the Pink City. The once-graceful view around Statue Circle is now marred by concrete towers. When the BJP came to power in the state in 2023, it briefly announced plans to restrict the tower to 15 storeys, but the project soon resumed unchanged.

A few metres from the chief secre-